▼ GLASSHOUSE



A PRESIDENTIAL SORTIE

It was no ordinary flight, and certainly no ordinary passenger. President Droupadi Murmu, strapped into the rear cockpit of a gleaming Rafale fighter, took to the skies over Haryana. Midway through the sortie, Air Chief Marshal A.P. Singh leaned in and informed her that they were flying right above historic Kurukshetra, the land of the Mahabharata war, and that the sacred Brahma Sarovar lay glistening below. Moved by the sight, the president couldn't hold back her emotions. In a moment that blended power with poetry, she radioed in a message. While praising the Rafale jet, she said: "I am witnessing the ancient land and the sacred Brahma Sarovar, symbols of our cultural diversity and historic journey. My faith in our military capability has become even stronger...." Stirring words from the First Citizen on both ancient battlefields and modern ones.

Illustrations by **SIDDHANT JUMDE**

▼ TROUBLED WATERS EVERYWHERE

TAKING THE PLUNGE

On November 2, while canvassing in Bihar's Begusarai, Congress leader **Rahul Gandhi** joined the Dalit fishermen there and took an impromptu plunge in a muddy pond. The Congress quickly contrasted Rahul's muck-soaked symbolism of Dalit solidarity with the cordoned off "sanitised pool" readied for Prime Minister Narendra Modi's Chhath rituals on the polluted Yamuna in Delhi. While Modi eventually skipped the event, Rahul's optics got murkier in Assam. Congress student wing NSUI mocked minister **Pijush Hazarika**, making a derogatory reference to him as a *mas bepari* (fish trader) while attacking him over an alleged AI-generated video. Hazarika, a Dalit, from the fisherfolk community, hit back, invoking Rahul's '*Mohabbat ki dukan*' slogan to accuse Congress of hypocrisy and an anti-Dalit bias, turning Rahul's muddy plunge into a political self-goal.

